

INDIA GEARS UP FOR AN INTERCONTINENTAL QUEST

Manolo Marquez takes charge of the Indian national football team, **facing the challenge** of revitalising the Blue Tigers, with his first test being the Intercontinental Cup in Hyderabad.

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After Igor Stimac's curtain call as India's national football team head coach, the spotlight falls on Manolo Marquez as he hopes to usher in a new chapter for the Blue Tigers.

Languishing at 124th in the official FIFA rankings and already out of contention for qualifying for the 2026 World Cup, the Indian ship is in choppy waters. Manolo needs to steady the hull and galvanise his crew.

In these turbulent conditions, he will be missing the services of veteran Sunil Chhetri, the former captain and India's record goalscorer who announced his international retirement after being a part of the Blue Tigers setup for 20 years. Manolo's first test comes in the Intercontinental Cup, where India will play Syria and Mauritius in a three-match tournament.

Taking charge: Manolo Marquez recently put out his list of 26 probables for the Intercontinental Cup, and there are some surprise additions.

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